LEARNING
MADE SIMPLE

Answer Key

Grade 1 Math | Grown-ups only

Name: _____ Date: _____

Subtraction Fact Strategies Within 20: answers

Page 1, Count Back

1. Example: 13 - 4 = 9 (start at 13, hop back to 12, 11, 10, 9)
2. 12 - 3 = 9 (hop back to 11, 10, 9)
3. 15 - 2 = 13 (hop back to 14, 13)
4. 11 - 4 = 7 (hop back to 10, 9, 8, 7)

Page 2, Count Up to Find the Difference

1. Example: 12 - 8 = 4 (count up 4 hops: 9, 10, 11, 12)
2. 14 - 11 = 3 (count up from 11 to 14)
3. 15 - 13 = 2 (count up from 13 to 15)
4. 11 - 7 = 4 (count up from 7 to 11)

Page 3, First, Get to 10

1. Example: 13 - 3 = 10 (take the 3 extra ones)
2. 15 - 5 = 10
3. 12 - 2 = 10
4. 14 - 4 = 10

© 2026 Learning Made Simple

LEARNING
MADE SIMPLE

Answer Key (continued)

Grade 1 Math | Grown-ups only

Name: _____ Date: _____

Page 4, Reach 10, Then Take the Rest

1. Example: 13 - 4 = 13 - 3 - 1 = 10 - 1 = 9
2. 12 - 5 = 12 - 2 - 3 = 10 - 3 = 7
3. 15 - 7 = 15 - 5 - 2 = 10 - 2 = 8

Page 5, Use Addition to Subtract

1. Example: 7 + 6 = 13; 13 - 6 = 7; 13 - 7 = 6
2. A. 9 + 4 = 13; 13 - 4 = 9; 13 - 9 = 4
3. A. 8 + 6 = 14; 14 - 6 = 8; 14 - 8 = 6
4. B. 15 - 9 = 6 (think 9 + 6 = 15)
5. B. 12 - 7 = 5 (think 7 + 5 = 12)

Page 6, Pick Your Strategy

1. 14 - 3 = 11. Most natural: Count Back.
2. 13 - 11 = 2. Most natural: Count Up.
3. 16 - 8 = 8. Most natural: Make 10.
4. 12 - 5 = 7. Most natural: Make 10.
5. 15 - 9 = 6. Most natural: Use Addition.
6. 11 - 4 = 7. Most natural: Count Back.

Note: Accept any strategy the child can show or explain that gives the correct difference.

Tip: on page 6, praise the strategy the child picked when the difference is right. The most natural fit is listed, not the only one.

© 2026 Learning Made Simple